

WEEK 5-2

# LIFETIME BANS, SAME BETTING DEALS

Five leagues moved to ban abusive bettors for life — without touching the sportsbook deals critics say fuel the abuse.

SPM 261, Introduction to Sport Management · Arcadia University Sport Management · September 2026

– FRAMING

# WHY THIS JOINT PROPOSAL IS A CASE STUDY

This past Tuesday, the NFL, NBA, MLB, NHL, and MLS — with their players' unions — sent gambling regulators in 35 states and D.C. a joint proposal: lifetime bans for bettors who harass or threaten athletes and their families. The reaction split into two stories — one about enforcement, one about who wrote the enforcement and who got left out of it.

FIVE THREADS IN THIS LECTURE

01

## THE JOINT PROPOSAL

Five leagues, one letter, 35 states plus D.C.

02

## HOW THE BAN WOULD WORK

Cross-state reporting and shared sportsbook exclusion lists

03

## THE DOUBLE-STANDARD CRITIQUE

Betting partnerships fans say fuel the harassment

04

## WHO GOT LEFT OUT

WNBPA and NWSLPA were not part of the letter

05

## THE MANAGEMENT LESSON

Duty of care versus the betting revenue model

01 REGULATORY FILING

# FIVE LEAGUES, ONE LETTER, 35 STATES

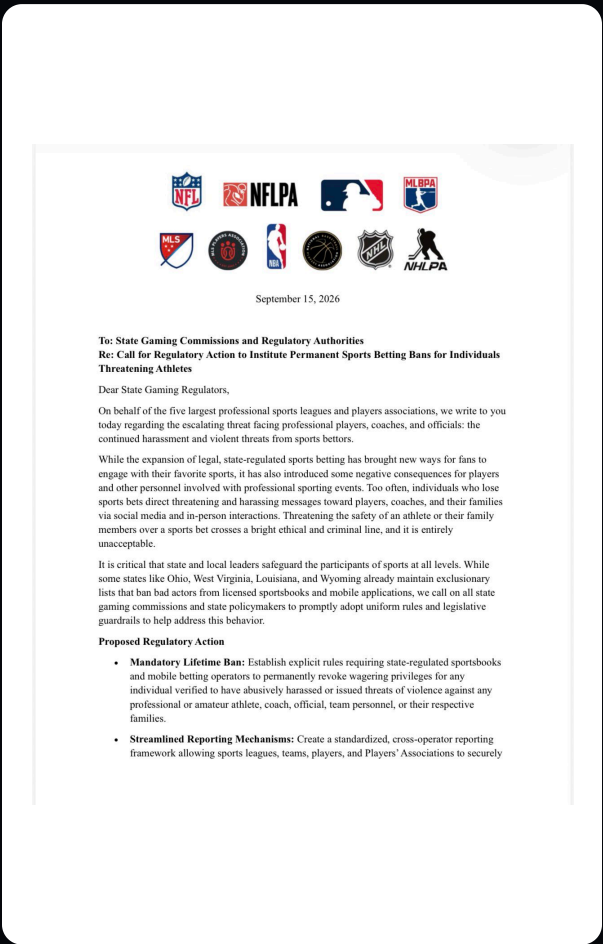
- NFL, NBA, MLB, NHL, and MLS — plus their players’ associations — signed the proposal.
- Sent this past Tuesday to gambling regulators in 35 states and Washington, D.C.
- Calls for lifetime bans on bettors who harass or threaten athletes or their families.

The Leagues’ Statement

“Threatening the safety of an athlete or their family members over a sports bet crosses a bright ethical and criminal line.”

[sports.yahoo.com/articles/sports-fans-call-nfl-nba-193114910.html](https://sports.yahoo.com/articles/sports-fans-call-nfl-nba-193114910.html)

The actual letter – page 1 of 2. Sept. 15, 2026.



02 ENFORCEMENT MECHANISM

# A SHARED SYSTEM ACROSS STATE LINES

1

## CROSS-STATE REPORTING

A threat reported in one state can be routed to regulators in others.

2

## SHARED EXCLUSION LISTS

A bettor banned by one operator can be flagged network-wide.

3

## AI ABUSE DETECTION

DraftKings and Fanatics already run AI platforms to flag social-media abuse aimed at athletes.

Four states — Louisiana, Ohio, West Virginia, and Wyoming — already run similar bettor-exclusion policies. The leagues' proposal would extend that model to regulators nationwide.

03 THE REVENUE SIDE

# THE SAME LEAGUES SELL THE BETS

- All five leagues carry official sportsbook partnerships.
- Betting odds and promos are now built directly into game broadcasts.
- Sportsbooks already run AI systems to catch the abuse the leagues are now moving to punish.

The Criticism, In One Line

**“You created this problem — now you’re punishing the symptom.”**

03

FAN AND MEDIA REACTION

# BACKLASH WAS IMMEDIATE

- Fans and sports media called the proposal hypocritical within hours of the letter going public.
- The core objection: leagues aggressively promote the betting behavior tied to the harassment they're now policing.
- The proposal punishes better conduct without touching the promotional pipeline that leagues built around it.

DISCUSSION

**If betting partnerships help fund the leagues now policing better behavior, who should own the harassment problem?**

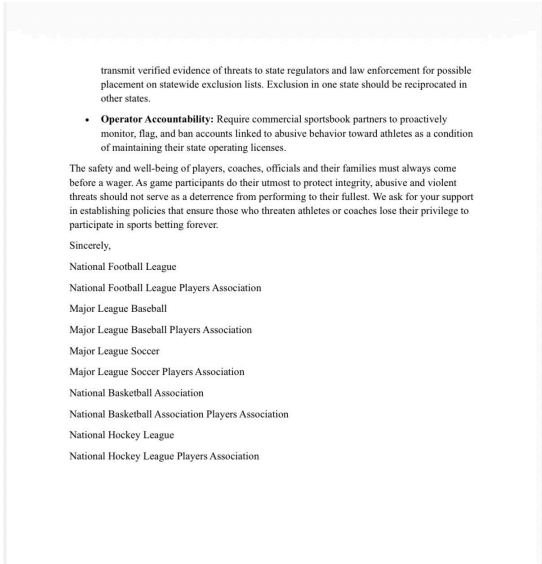
04 A GAP IN THE COALITION

# TWO UNIONS WERE MISSING FROM THE LETTER

- The WNBA Players Association was not included in the joint letter.
- The National Women’s Soccer League Players Association was also left out.
- NWSLPA reportedly learned about the memo only after it had already gone public.

WNBPA Statement

The union said it was “deeply disappointed” at being excluded from the proposal.



04 STAKEHOLDER MANAGEMENT

# A SAFETY POLICY WITH AN EXCLUSION PROBLEM

- Women's leagues face the same betting-harassment exposure as the men's leagues that wrote the letter.
- Leaving two players' unions out undercuts the leagues' own stated safety rationale.
- The gap raises a basic stakeholder question: who gets a seat when the policy is drafted, and who finds out after the fact.

DISCUSSION

**What does it mean for a duty-of-care policy to exclude unions representing athletes most exposed to this harassment?**

## 05 DUTY OF CARE VS. REVENUE MODEL

# WHERE THE BETTING BUSINESS MEETS ITS OWN POLICY

## THE REVENUE MODEL

- Official sportsbook partnerships
- In-broadcast betting content
- League-branded betting products

## THE DUTY-OF-CARE MOVE

- Lifetime bans for harassers
- Cross-state reporting
- Shared exclusion lists

## THE STAKEHOLDER GAP

- WNBPA excluded
- NWSLPA excluded
- Coalition covers 5 leagues, not all

The same institutions that built the betting pipeline are now the ones enforcing its boundaries — and not every stakeholder got a say in where those boundaries sit.

– SYNTHESIS

# WHY THIS MATTERS FOR SPORT MANAGERS

A

A safety policy can coexist with the revenue model that critics say created the need for it.

B

Cross-league, cross-state coordination is possible when leagues share a legal and reputational interest.

C

Excluding stakeholders from a joint policy creates a visible equity gap, even when the policy itself is defensible.

D

Enforcement mechanisms — bans, shared lists, AI detection — are easier to stand up than fixing the incentive structure underneath.

– DISCUSSION

# WRAP-UP QUESTIONS

- 1 **Can a league credibly police bettor behavior while expanding the betting partnerships that help drive it?**
- 2 **Should the WNBPA and NWSLPA have been part of this proposal from the start — and what should change now?**
- 3 **Who should own the cost of fixing a harassment problem: the leagues, the sportsbooks, or the bettors themselves?**

— SOURCES

# REFERENCES

- Yahoo Sports — coverage of the leagues' joint proposal on bettor harassment and the hypocrisy criticism it drew.
- Adam Schefter, via X/Twitter — initial report of the leagues' joint letter to gambling regulators.

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